Seleucus, and remained in Hellenistic control for several generations. This proximity produced the Greco-Bactrian and Indo-Greek kingdoms in the far north of the subcontinent.

India and its adjacent northern neighbors fell under the heavy influence of the Hellenistic conquerors, while the central part of the subcontinent remained united under the leadership of Emperor Shunga. To the far south, the Kingdom of Kalinga had regained its independence from external empires, as did the Pandyan Dynasty and multiple small to mid-sized regions. Here, a cultural divide began to show between the people of the north and the people of the south. The southern Indians were not untouched by the hand of the Greeks, yet they persevered as a culture of mostly Vedic and Hindu people. In the north, religions were plentiful and even faddish in their adoption one after another. The northerners under Asian and Greek rule practiced Buddhism, Hinduism, Jainism, Hellenism, and Zoroastrianism. Since the Greeks had long worshiped multiple gods, their evolving beliefs merged well with those of their Indian, Chinese, and Pakistani colonies.

In eastern central India, Pushyamitra Shunga was a follower of the Vedic god, Lord Shiva, and as such, he put a target on the Buddhists of his realm. Beyond promoting Shiva, Emperor Shunga actively had Buddhists killed to purify his monotheistic beliefs; it is perhaps due to this blatant form of ethnic cleansing that Buddhism shrank so significantly out of favor in most of India. Shunga was just as dedicated to warfare for the sake of territorial gain as Ashoka had been against it, and through a series of battles he took about one-third of the total land India and adjacent regions had to offer.

Though Shunga and his nine dynastic successors were quick to the sword, theirs was a period of Indian history in which the arts and education grew. It was through royal Shunga patronage that literature, architecture, and the pursuit of higher education and artistic pursuits was achievable for citizens of the empire. The archaeological record of that period, from about 184 BCE to 73 BCE, includes a variety of finely detailed jewelry, small terra-cotta sculptures, large sculptures, tablets, and architectural monuments. The latter includes the chaitya hall at Bhaja and the renowned Great Stupa at Sanchi. Though the first Emperor Shunga murdered Buddhists outright, later dynastic rulers took a more reverent attitude toward those members of the peaceful faith, repairing the monuments of Ashoka respectfully.